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COMPSCI 132 Tic Tac Toe Game

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04-28-2026

Introduction

The purpose of this project was to design and implement a fully functional Tic-Tac-Toe game using different programming concepts that we learned in class such as functions, data structures, and control flow. Tic-Tac-Toe is a simple two-player game played on a 3x3 grid, where players take turns marking spaces with their symbol (usually “X” or “O”). The objective is to align three of one’s symbols horizontally, vertically, or diagonally when someone successfully does this, they win.

This implementation creates a user-friendly, interactive experience while also maintaining clean, readable, and well-structured code. The program ensures that all rules of the game are enforced and handles edge cases such as invalid input and tie conditions.

Structure and Design

The program is divided into logical components using functions. This modular approach helps to improve the readability, maintainability, and the reusability of the code. Each function is responsible for a specific task, such as displaying the board, handling inputs from players, or checking for a winner.

The game board is typically represented using a list (or array) data structure. A list of nine elements is used to simulate the 3x3 grid. Each position represents a space on the board and is updated as a player decides their next move.

Example structure of the board:

- Index positions 0–2 represent the top row
- Index positions 3–5 represent the middle row
- Index positions 6–8 represent the bottom row

This linear structure simplifies indexing and makes it easier to check winning conditions.

Key Features

1. Game Board Display

A function is used to print the current state of the board after each move. This ensures that players can clearly see the game progress. The board is formatted using a grid layout, making it intuitive and very easy for the player to read.

2. Player Input Handling

The program lets players enter their move by selecting a position on the board. Input validation is a key part of this step. The program ensures that:

- The input is within the valid range (1–9)
- The chosen position has not already been taken up

If invalid input is detected, the player is prompted again until a valid move is entered.

3. Turn Management

The game alternates between two players, typically represented as “X” and “O”. A variable is used to track the current player, and it switches after each allowed move. This ensures fair gameplay and proper sequencing of turns.

4. Win Detection

One of the most important components of the game is checking for a winner. The program evaluates all possible winning combinations, including:

- Horizontal rows
- Vertical columns
- Diagonals

If any of these combinations contain the same symbol, the game declares the player using those symbols as the winner and ends the game.

5. Tie Condition

If all positions on the board are filled and no player has gotten any of the winning combinations, the game is declared a draw. This prevents the game from continuing indefinitely and provides a clear outcome.

Structures Used

The primary data structure used in this implementation is a list. Lists are ideal for this application because they allow easy indexing and modification of elements. Each move updates a specific index in the list, reflecting the current state of the board.

Additionally, the use of lists simplifies the process of checking winning conditions, as specific index patterns can be evaluated efficiently.

Code Organization and Readability

The code is organized into clearly defined functions, each with a specific responsibility. This modular design makes the program easier to understand and debug. Meaningful variable names are used throughout the code to improve readability.

Proper indentation and formatting are also maintained, which contributes to overall code clarity.

Edge Case Handling

The program includes mechanisms to handle various edge cases, ensuring reliability. These include:

- Rejecting invalid inputs (e.g., non-numeric or out-of-range values)
- Preventing moves in already occupied positions
- Detecting and handling tie games
- Ensuring the game stops once a winner is declared

By addressing these edge cases, the program avoids common runtime errors and provides a smoother user experience.

Enhancements and Possible Improvements

While the current implementation meets all basic requirements, several enhancements could be added to improve functionality and user experience:

- Implementing a single-player mode with an AI opponent
- Adding difficulty levels for the AI opponent

- Creating a graphical user interface (GUI) instead of a text-based interface
- Allowing players to restart the game without restarting the program
- Keeping track of player scores across multiple rounds

These enhancements would make the game more engaging and demonstrate more advanced programming skills.

Conclusion

This Tic-Tac-Toe game implementation successfully demonstrates the use of fundamental programming concepts, including functions, loops, conditionals, and data structures. The program is well-organized, easy to understand, and handles all necessary game logic and edge cases.

Overall, the project meets the required functionality and provides a solid foundation for further development. With additional features and improvements, it could be expanded into a more complex and interactive application.